

Clean and Unclean: The Logic of Purity

Purity in the Bible is not hygiene and it is not, by itself, sin. It is a map of order and boundary, and you cannot read Leviticus, the Gospels, or Acts 10 without it.

THE FRAME

Not Hygiene. Not Sin. Order.

Modern readers meet the word unclean and reach for one of two files. Either it means dirty, a hygiene problem, or it means wicked, a moral problem. Both files are wrong, and both will wreck your reading of a third of the Old Testament.

In Israel's law, a woman who gave birth was unclean. A man who buried his father was unclean. A couple who obeyed the command to be fruitful and multiply contracted impurity in the act. None of these people had sinned. They had touched the boundaries of life and death, the places where mortal bodies leak, fail, and end, and the system marked those encounters and prescribed a way back to ordinary standing. Impurity was a state, usually temporary, often unavoidable, and frequently the result of doing something good.

The anthropologist Mary Douglas put the underlying logic in one sentence. Dirt is matter out of place. A purity system is a society's map of where things belong, and the map exists to say something. Israel's map said that the Holy One had pitched his tent among mortals, and that life and death do not mix in his presence.

LEVITICUS

The Map and What It Meant

Leviticus 10:10 states the priestly job description. Distinguish between the holy and the common, and between the unclean and the clean. Picture concentric circles. The holy at the center, the sanctuary where God dwells. Around it the clean, the ordinary ground of daily life. At the edges the unclean, the zone of death and disorder. Persons and things moved between these states, and the law regulated the traffic.

The sources of impurity were not random. Corpses. Skin disease that made the body waste visibly. Genital discharges, the leaking of the fluids of life. Certain animals that blurred the categories of creation. The scholar Jacob Milgrom spent a lifetime on these chapters and argued that the common thread is death. Impurity is the aura of mortality, and it must not be carried into the presence of the living God. The food laws added a second function. They marked Israel's boundary in the world, a people made distinct down to the kitchen.

We find this strange, and we should let it stay strange for a while before resolving it. The strangeness is the lesson. Holiness, in this system, is not a feeling. It is a geography.

THE GOSPELS

Jesus Reverses the Flow

In the normal physics of purity, contamination flows one way. The unclean infects the clean. Touch a leper and you become unclean. The leper does not become whole. This is why the diseased were quarantined outside the camp and why the woman with the twelve-year hemorrhage in Mark 5 had to approach Jesus from behind, in a crowd, hoping not to be noticed. Everything she touched, she rendered unclean. She had twelve years of being a hazard to everyone she loved.

Then the physics break. Jesus stretches out his hand and touches the leper, and instead of impurity flowing in, cleansing flows out. The woman touches his garment and power goes out from him, and he calls her daughter in front of the crowd that she had been hiding from. He takes a dead girl by the hand, the strongest contagion in the whole system, and the girl gets up.

Jesus does not mock the purity map or wave it away. He fulfills its deepest hope from the other direction. The holy is no longer merely guarded. In him it has gone on offense. Holiness has become the contagious thing.

ACTS 10

What Peter's Vision Abolished, and What It Did Not

On a rooftop in Joppa, Peter sees a sheet lowered from heaven full of clean and unclean animals together, and hears a command. Kill and eat. He refuses three times, and the voice answers, what God has made clean, do not call common.

Notice what Peter does with the vision. He does not go order a meal. He goes to the house of Cornelius, a Gentile, and gives the interpretation himself. God has shown me that I should not call any person common or unclean. The food map had become a wall between Jew and Gentile at the table, and in Christ the wall had come down. That is what the vision abolished, the use of purity as a barrier against people God was calling.

What it did not abolish is everything else we sometimes load onto it. It did not abolish moral seriousness. The same church that welcomed Cornelius still named sin as sin. It did not abolish holiness. Be holy, for I am holy, stands in Leviticus and is quoted without apology in 1 Peter. The boundary between the church and uncleanness did not vanish. It moved inward, from the kitchen to the heart, which is a harder place to keep clean.

THE MIRROR

We Still Draw the Map

It would be comfortable to file purity under ancient curiosities. But every community still runs purity software, including the ones that have never read Leviticus. We have people we will not touch, opinions that contaminate by association, whole categories of neighbor we treat as contagious. Watch what happens in a church lobby when the visibly addicted, the politically wrong, or the recently scandalous walk in. The system activates without a single word. I have felt it activate in me, that small instinctive step backward, and called it discernment.

The gospel's answer is not that nothing is unclean. It is that in Christ the flow has reversed, and his people are sent to touch what the world quarantines, expecting holiness to be the stronger contagion.

That is what the purity laws were always pointing toward, a God who does not stay at the center of the map but crosses it. The question the old map leaves with us is not whether we believe in clean and unclean. We do, all of us, every day. The question is which direction we expect the contagion to run.

KEY TEXTS

Leviticus 10:10

Mark 5:25-34

Acts 10:9-16

SOURCES

Purity and Danger — Mary Douglas

Leviticus: A Book of Ritual and Ethics — Jacob Milgrom

Honor, Patronage, Kinship and Purity — David A. deSilva